

Genocide The deliberate, targeted killing of, or causing serious harm to, a large group of people, especially an entire religious group, race, or nation.

Habeas corpus (Latin for “you shall have the body.”) The right of a person who is imprisoned or detained to appear before a *court* of law to establish whether their detention is lawful. A *writ of habeas corpus* orders the custodian to bring the detainee before the court.

Hearing A proceeding before a *court* or another legal decision-making body. A hearing is generally shorter and less formal than a *trial*.

Human rights Freedoms and *rights* that are inherent to all human beings and defined and protected by law. Examples of human rights include the right to life, liberty, and security.

Indictment A formal written accusation of a crime.

Intellectual property Creations or inventions that are protected by laws such as *patents*, *copyright*, and *trademarks*, enabling people to claim recognition for or benefit financially from what they create.

International law A system of laws covering the rights and duties of *sovereign* nations.

Judge A public official with the authority to preside over legal matters and *court* proceedings.

Judgment The final decision of a *court* or *judge* on a legal matter.

Judicial review The process whereby the *judiciary* can review the lawfulness of a decision or

ruling made by the *legislature* or *executive*, providing an essential system of checks and balances. A key example of judicial review is the power of the US Supreme Court to decide whether a law violates the US Constitution.

Judiciary The branch of government that is responsible for administering justice and includes the *judges* and *courts* of law.

Jurisdiction The power of a *state*, *court*, or *judge* to make legal decisions and enforce laws. For example, a state may have jurisdiction over people, property, or circumstances within its territory.

Jury A body of people, known as jurors, who are sworn to give a *verdict* on a *court* case on the basis of *evidence* submitted to them.

Law code A comprehensive and systematic written collection of laws adopted by a nation or *state*.

Law enforcement The process of ensuring compliance with the law by means of arrests, punishment, rehabilitation, and deterrence.

Lawsuit In *civil law*, a *court* case in which a *plaintiff* claims to have suffered a loss as a result of a *defendant's* wrongful actions.

Legislation A law or set of laws that is being prepared, enacted, or passed.

Legislature The branch of government that is responsible for making and passing laws.

Litigation The process of resolving a dispute between two or more opposing parties in *court*.

Magistrate A judicial official—or justice of the peace (JP) in England and Wales—who administers the law in *courts* that deal with minor crimes.

Magna Carta A charter of *rights* drafted in 1215 to limit abuses of power by the English monarchy.

Mandate A command or the authority to act in a certain way given to a government representative by an electorate.

Martial law Military control that replaces the normal civilian government of a country, usually to maintain order in times of crisis.

Nation-state An independent *state* in which the majority of the *citizens* share a common language and culture. These citizens identify as a nation and the state is ruled in their name.

Natural law A system of justice held to be common to all people and derived from the unchanging rules of nature rather than from the changing rules of society.

Papal bull An order or *edict* issued by the Pope on a matter of religious, legal, or political importance.

Parliament The law-making branch, or *legislature*, of a country's government, often made up of elected politicians.

Patent A form of legal protection that grants inventors ownership of their idea and ensures that other people cannot copy the invention without the inventor's permission. A patent protects an invention, whereas *copyright* protects the expression of an idea.